

8.1 Caring for Water Country

For thousands of years, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people managed and cared for Country, as part of their culture and custodianship. Through this, Aboriginal communities have become significant knowledge holders of the Australian environment and how to manage it sustainably.

When learning about Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander perspectives, it is important to ensure you are listening to Aboriginal voices and perspectives. For this reason, watch these two videos of Aboriginal peoples discussing the importance of Water Country, and ways these groups manage water environments in the past and today.

Video 1

Watch [NSW Government Western Local Land Services: Through Our Eyes - Gilgais and Caring for Water with June Barker](#). Answer the questions.

1. What are gilgais and why were they important to the people in this area?
2. Why were people not allowed to paddle or trample in the gilgais?
3. How did Aboriginal people collect crayfish safely?
4. What method did they use to make muddy water clear and safe to drink?
5. Why is it important to burn the gypsum before using it in water?
6. How have changes to the land, such as fences or livestock, affected the gilgais?
7. What does this video show about the way Aboriginal people interact with and care for water?
8. How might these traditional methods of caring for water be useful today?

Video 2

Watch [CSIRO: Traditional Indigenous Science to Solve Modern Water Problems - Meet Mibu Fischer](#). Answer the questions.

1. Who is Mibu Fischer, and what is a “Marine Ethnoecologist”?
2. Why does she say climate change affects Indigenous communities “first”?
3. How does she describe her connection to Quandamooka Country and water?
4. Why do Indigenous people feel an obligation to care for Country?
5. How does Mibu explain the value of Indigenous knowledge in managing marine environments?
6. What challenges exist when combining Indigenous knowledge with Western science?
7. What activities does Mibu do in her work to protect water and marine environments?
8. How can using both Indigenous and Western knowledge help solve environmental problems like climate change or water scarcity?

Optional extension:

Research additional strategies utilised by First Nations peoples when managing Water Country. The following resources are a good starting point.

https://www.resources.qld.gov.au/_data/assets/pdf_file/0007/1408282/aboriginal-peoples-manage-water-resources.pdf

<https://www.waterquality.gov.au/anz-guidelines/guideline-values/derive/cultural-values/principles>